Caring about others and protecting information

Social preferences × public goods × free riding × information asymmetry

01 People act for more than self-interest

People consider others' interests, fairness, cooperation and returning favors, as well as their own benefit. They sometimes help others at some cost to themselves. These tendencies are called social preferences: altruism, fairness, reciprocity and conditional cooperation.

02 Public goods and free riding

Pooling information and sharing burdens increases group benefits. But if people can benefit without bearing costs, they have an incentive to take from others without contributing: free riding. If everyone does this, cooperation collapses.
Mutual information contributions → more information → benefits for both.
Contribute nothing → use others' information → free riding.

03 Sharing with colleagues

Trusted colleagues sharing industry trends and ways to work can complement information that no individual could collect alone. Reciprocal sharing creates gains from cooperation: a concrete example of reciprocity.

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04 Telling everyone is not always optimal

Giving information to rivals seeking the same customers or work may improve their decisions and proposals, reducing your informational advantage. Social preferences and unconditional disclosure are different matters.

Counterparty	Sharing pattern	Effect
Trusted colleagues	Mutual sharing	Information can complement each other
Those who do not reciprocate	One-way sharing	Risk of free riding
Competitors in the same market	Information leakage	Your informational advantage may fall

05 What matters is whom you share with

Information has value; universal disclosure dilutes scarcity. Weigh the benefits of cooperation against the competitive advantage lost by providing information. Game theory, reciprocity and information asymmetry matter alongside social preferences. Cooperation creates value; information is also competitive strength. Choosing whom to cooperate with and how much to share is a strategy.